

YEAR 2 | VOLUME 7 | JANUARY 2026

COLONEL'S MILITARY & DEFENCE ARMOURY

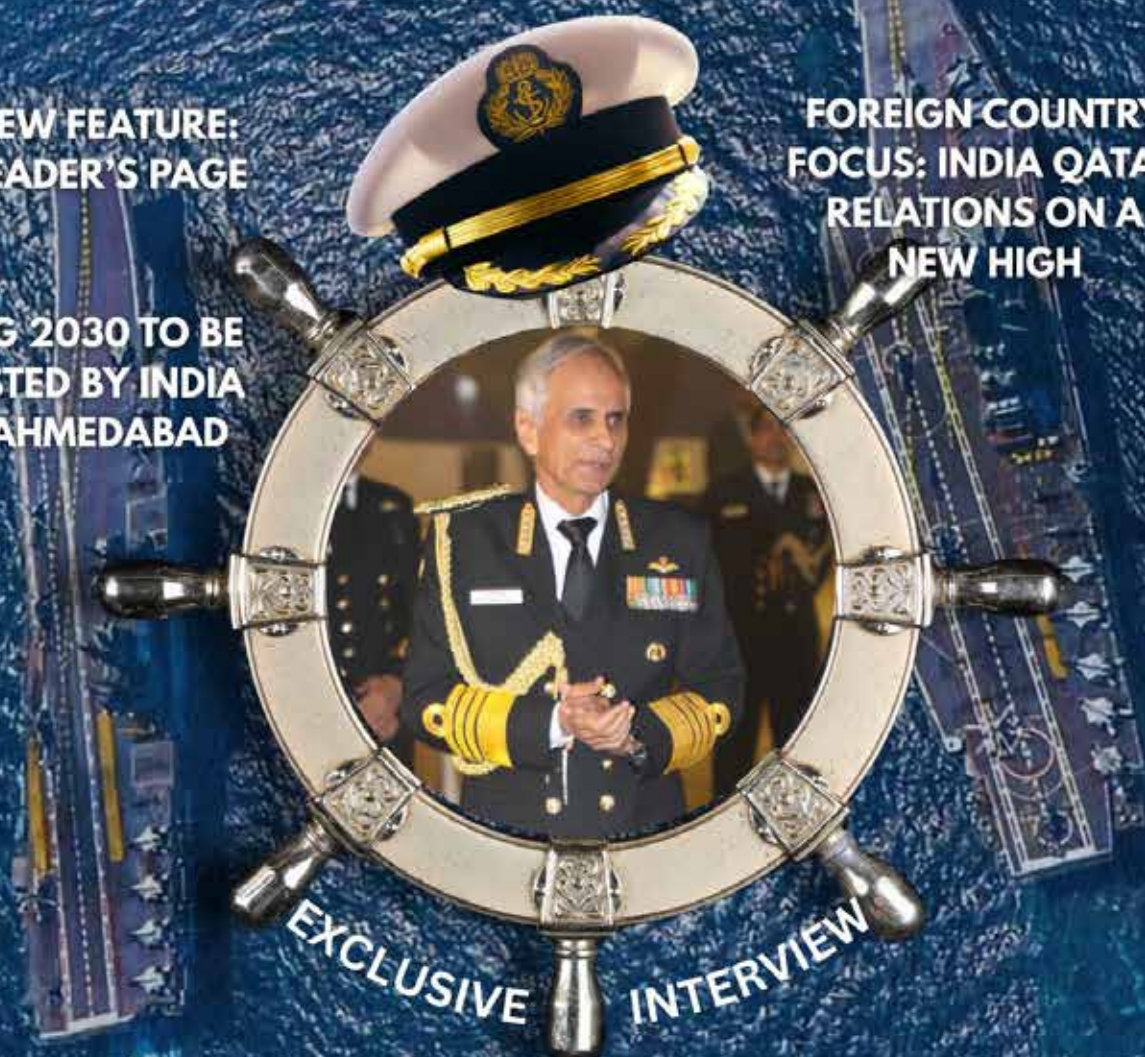


**NEW FEATURE:
READER'S PAGE**



**CWG 2030 TO BE
HOSTED BY INDIA
IN AHMEDABAD**

**FOREIGN COUNTRY
FOCUS: INDIA QATAR
RELATIONS ON A
NEW HIGH**



**EXCLUSIVE
INTERVIEW**

ADMIRAL KARAMBIR SINGH (RETD.)

ON THE OCCASION OF INDIAN NAVY DAY



**NAVY COMMISSIONS MH-60R SEAHAWK
HELICOPTERS SQN AT INS HANSA**



**INDIA WELCOMES PRESIDENT PUTIN IN
INDIA FOR 23RD BILATERAL SUMMIT**



**DEEPAWALI ENTERS UNESCO
HERITAGE LIST**

**SPECIALLY DESIGNED FOR ALL OF YOU PREPARING FOR
SSB & CIVIL SERVICES INTERVIEWS**

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FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF'S DESK



A big hello to all our readers, in this New Year, 2026, which ushers hope and bonhomie all around us. Why, because India is poised to achieve many new milestones in its relentless march to development & prosperity; and we at **Team CMDA** are with you, in this exciting journey of success & achievements, both personal & collective!



Friends, many among you will be facing your SSB & other professional interviews soon, starting Feb-March, so remember the basic rules and remain calm & cool after all, there can only be two results possible-i.e. Pass or Fail, so embrace & accept failure. Though it's difficult to digest, the fact is that after being unsuccessful, we blame everyone else, including the weather, except the real culprit, which is you yourself! since you didn't prepare well, you couldn't answer properly. Once you have introspected and accepted your fault(s), try again with greater josh & vigour and now only one result is possible, which is PASS, and this you shall!

Dear Readers, continuing with our monthly themes, December was the month of Navy Day, celebrated on 4th Dec, commemorating **Operation Trident**, the successful naval assault on Karachi during the 1971 Indo-Pakistan War, recognizing its power, innovation, and self-reliance in safeguarding India's maritime borders. The day showcases the Navy's capabilities through events like air displays and ship visits, promoting public awareness and fostering international cooperation. Towards this, Team CMDA caught up with **Admiral Karambir Singh, our 24th Navy Chief** from May 2019 to Nov 2021, at the Manekshaw Centre, Delhi Cantt, on the sidelines of the Indo-Pacific Regional Dialogue 2025, Indian Navy's annual apex-level strategic conference, held from 28 to 30th October 2025. So, read all about this interesting & inspiring conversation in the **exclusive Interview of the month** and know the Admiral closely and learn from his advice!

As regards **International News**, Sr News-writer **Shivam Jha** reports about India-Oman trade ties deepening, after PM Modi's state visit to the country on 18-19 Dec; and follows it up with news of PM further visiting Jordan & Ethiopia, with the latter awarding him their highest civilian honour. He also reports about the much-awaited visit by Russian President Putin to India, for the 23rd India-Russia Annual summit, with a slew of bilateral agreements/MOUs being signed, on its sidelines.

Towards **National Events**, our Journalist **Nandini Kumari** talks about the



Our other enterprise, Team ESELEI, successfully completed a 5 weeks English Language-cum-SSB Trg Module at Bhatinda Cantt, in this month.

Winter Session of Parliament and its various deliberations/Bills passed or presented, though most of the session again got washed away! Next, she talks of Deepavali, India's festival of lights, having been inscribed on UNESCO's List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity 2025, marking a major recognition. She also tells us about the newly introduced- Bharat Taxi scheme, which will challenge ride, hailing giants with a driver owned model; plus talks about the implementation of the 4 new Labour Codes set to modernise workforce protection.

Our Defence Correspondent, Mahima brings us news that India Navy has commissioned a MH-60R Seahawk Sqn at INS Hansa. These modern & heavily armed heptrs, were recently imported from USA. She also tells us that HAL Tejas MK-1A delivery revision highlights production bottlenecks, while the TATA-Lockheed C-130J MRO hub takes shape in Bengaluru. She further brings news of the Indian Army's joint **Ex Surya Kiran** with the Nepal Army & **Ex Ekuverin**, with the Maldivian Defence Forces. In the end, she brings news of CLAWS & Indian Army jointly conducting the 3rd Chanakya Defence Dialogue, which I also attended, being a Sr Visiting Fellow & PhD Guide at this premier think tank of ours!

As regards **Science, Tech & Environment News**, **Yuvanshi Hooda** reports about Cyclone Ditwah devastating Sri Lanka & its neighbouring nations; highlights why Goa may soon get a tiger reserve of its own; talks of how Tamil Nadu continues to lead India's public health battle with AIDS & TB; talks of India expanding its Ramsar footprint, with 2 new wetlands being added & discusses ways to protect the Aravalli Range, which is in news lately, all due to wrong reasons!

Towards Management & Business News-Anand Srivastava analyses why the Indian Rupee is feeling the heat & crashing against the \$ now; and gives news of India posting its fastest growth figures in the last 6 Quarters, plus gives us those **30 Quiz Questions** to rack your brain with!



Wrt Sports News, **our Sports desk has a new incumbent, Mr Yogesh Dixit**, a 23-year-old MBA student with a strong foundation in Economics and practical exposure to Human Resource practices. He passed out from APS, Dhaula Kuan in 2020 and was awarded Best Sports Person & Best Athlete, besides being a keen debater. He's previously worked as a Project Assistant at IIT Delhi and has performed leadership roles in academics & extracurricular activities, wherein he brings a blend of analytical thinking, people management & adaptability to dynamic business environments. We **welcome him warmly to Team CMDA**. Read all about sports news written by him in the inside pages.

Dear patrons, this month's **reader's page** features Poems and writings of Sr students from Nitinand Public School, Rohtak, which, under the dynamic leadership of its Director, Mr Sumit Malik, is going from strength to strength. Plus, we have our regular sections- **the CSE Mains Questions**, with one solved for you, **plus the Special Foreign Country Focus**, where we feature **Oman & its friendship with India**.

Readers, we're ready for collaboration with schools & colleges to showcase their talented writers. Do get in touch with the Ed-in-Chief or our marketing man, the original **Master Anjaney Singh**, who returns to the Team after a brief hiatus, wherein he's qualified for the IIT, and is pursuing Mechanical Engineering at IIT, Kanpur. Keep watching this space month after month for authentic & properly analysed & unbiased news, by my team of young professionals - **"TEAM CMDA"**

Pl renew your subscriptions, both print & digital (it's coming to you in a new avatar, just wait & watch), for whomsoever it's due. Happy Reading! Do send in your feedbacks on our mail/SM handles!

JAI HIND Col (Dr) Bhasker Gupta (retd), cmda.newsmag@gmail.com

INTERVIEW OF THE MONTH

ADMIRAL KARAMBIR SINGH

PVSM, AVSM, ADC (Retd), Former Chief of the Naval Staff & Chairman, Naval Maritime Foundation

Admiral Karambir Singh (Retd), was India's 24th Chief of Naval Staff, from May 2019 to Nov 2021. He later assumed the Chairmanship of the National Maritime Foundation, New Delhi, on 17 January 2022. He is also the Distinguished Chair at the Naval War College, Goa.



An alumnus of NDA, Khadakwasla, the Defence Services Staff College, Wellington & College of Naval Warfare, Mumbai, the Admiral was commissioned into the Indian Navy in July 1980. A helicopter pilot, he has flown on the Chetak (Alouette Mk III) and several variants of Kamov helicopters. He has commanded the Indian Coast Guard Ship Chandbibi, the guided-missile corvette INS Vijaydurg, and two of the Indian Navy's frontline guided-missile destroyers, namely, INS Rana & INS Delhi. He has tenanted most seagoing appointments, including those of Fleet Operations Officer of the Western Fleet.

On promotion to flag rank, he served as the Chief of Staff of Eastern Naval Command. He has also tenanted other critical flag-appointments, including those of Chief of Staff of the Tri-Services Unified Command in Andaman & Nicobar Islands, and the Flag Officer Commanding Maharashtra and Gujarat Naval Area (FOMAG). As a Vice-Admiral, he was the Director-General, Project Seabird, Deputy Chief of Naval Staff, Vice Chief of Naval Staff and the Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Eastern Naval Command. He assumed Command of the Indian Navy on 31 May 2019, serving until his retirement from active service till 30 November 2021.

The Admiral was honoured with the prestigious award of the **“Order of the Rising Sun, Gold and Silver Star (2nd Highest order)”** by the government of Japan for strengthening the collaborative efforts between India and Japan in the realm of national defence, particularly in the context of achieving a free and open Indo-Pacific region.

Team CMDA was fortunate enough to get an exclusive with Admiral Karambir on the sidelines of the **Indo-Pacific Regional Dialogue, held at Manekshaw Centre, Delhi Cantt.**

TEAM CMDA IN CONVERSATION WITH ADMIRAL KARAMBIR SINGH

Q1: CMDA During your tenure, the Indian Navy focused heavily on indigenization and self-reliance. How do you view the evolution of the Navy's journey since then?

Ans: Admiral Karambir Singh

(AKS): The Indian Navy began its indigenisation journey early, building its first indigenous ship in 1964, following the creation of the Directorate of Naval Design in the 1950s and integration bodies in the 1960s. This long, principle-driven effort has enabled the Navy to design, build, and operate its own warships.



Today, indigenous content stands at 90–95% in hulls, around 70% in propulsion, and 60–65% in weapons and sensors. All warships are now built in India. With technology evolving rapidly, indigenisation is being strengthened through sustained investment in R&D, academia, start-ups, and industry. *Atmanirbharat* today is a reality, not merely a slogan. The Navy has moved from being a *buyers' Navy* to a *builders' Navy* and is steadily progressing towards becoming an *exporters' Navy*.

Q2: CMDA: Considering the increasing Chinese presence in the Indian Ocean Region, does India's maritime strategy need recalibration, or are we adequately prepared?

Ans: AKS: Maritime strategy is fundamentally about protecting and advancing India's maritime interests. These interests exist irrespective of China's presence. As India moves towards becoming a developed nation and targets a 30 trillion-dollar economy by 2047, our dependence on the seas for trade, energy, and mobility will only increase.

That said, maritime strategy must also respond to challenges. China represents one of our most significant challenges. As its comprehensive national power has grown, China has expanded westwards in a deliberate and methodical manner to secure resources, markets, and energy routes. This is evident through the Belt and Road Initiative, overseas bases, strategic footholds, and defence exports in our neighbourhood.



The Chinese Navy is modernising and expanding faster than any navy in history. Its presence in the Indian Ocean Region is not benign. Given the asymmetry in national power, India's approach should focus on containment and behaviour modification rather than confrontation. Our strategy must be multi-pronged: containment, asymmetric responses, collaboration with like-minded partners, and ensuring that no power vacuum emerges in the Indian Ocean Region. Power vacuums are quickly exploited, and India must remain proactive across the region.

Q3: CMDA: During your tenure, the indigenous aircraft carrier INS Vikrant gained momentum. What challenges did you face in achieving self-reliance in such a complex platform?

Ans: AKS: INS Vikrant was a decade-long effort and India's first indigenous aircraft carrier. Very few navies have built aircraft carriers. One challenge was the decision to use indigenous steel, which took 3-4 years to develop, leading to delays, but it was a conscious choice aligned with self-reliance.

The Navy's role was to act as an enabler. Cochin Shipyard faced challenges, including disruptions during COVID-19 and the absence of foreign OEMs. We facilitated virtual collaboration, expedited decisions, and even carried out complex technical alignments through video conferencing. We adopted a pragmatic approach, sought assistance when required, and ensured quick decision-making. Despite delays, the project was completed within budget and remains a deeply satisfying achievement.

Q4: CMDA: How are initiatives like Project 75 and indigenous submarine programmes shaping India's undersea warfare capabilities?

Ans: AKS: India adopted a long-term submarine construction plan in the 1990s, starting with Project 75 and followed by subsequent ones. The idea was to collaborate initially and then progressively move towards indigenous construction of both conventional and nuclear submarines.

Under Project 75 (India), the next set of submarines will be the last built with foreign collaboration. Through the strategic partnership model, MDL is working with Germany's TKMS. Parallely, India is designing and building its own nuclear submarines.

The future will also see the integration of unmanned and un-crewed underwater vehicles to supplement traditional submarines. Indigenization is progressing steadily, and future submarine programmes will be entirely indigenous.

Q5: CMDA: What qualities should a young naval officer develop to become an effective leader in the future?

Ans: AKS: Certain leadership values are timeless. One such value is service before self, ingrained from my days at the National Defence Academy. A young officer must be a thorough professional with strong foundational knowledge and a commitment to lifelong learning. Technology will define future warfare, so officers must be comfortable with technological change and be team players. Future conflicts will be complex and multi-domain, requiring strong critical thinking and emotional intelligence. While artificial intelligence may provide answers, human judgment and empathy will remain decisive.



Q6: CMDA: How do humanitarian assistance and disaster relief missions contribute to India's regional role and blue-water navy aspirations?

Ans: AKS: Humanitarian assistance is not about image-building; it is about being a friend in need. Such missions build trust, goodwill, and cohesion. If we truly believe that the world is one family, assistance must be extended altruistically.



The Indian Navy aims to be the preferred first responder and security partner in the region. Today, Indian naval ships operate across the Indo-Pacific, the Atlantic, and key choke points year-round. By operational standards, India already functions as a blue-water navy. Our broader objective is to build collective maritime competence across the region.

Q7:CMDA: What should be India's long-term maritime vision for 2047, when we complete 100 years of independence?

Ans: AKS: Maritime vision extends far beyond the Navy. It involves over twenty stakeholders across the maritime sector. Initiatives such as Maritime India Vision 2030, Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, Sagarmala, and indigenous shipbuilding must progress together.

The blue economy is central to this vision. The seas provide oxygen, food, energy, and trade routes. Nearly 95 percent of India's trade moves by sea, making it essential to keep the seas free, open, inclusive, and secure through partnerships, collaboration, and rule-shaping.

Q8: CMDA: Sir, among the many, which was the most defining experience of your naval career?

Ans: AKS: Every appointment had its own challenges and rewards. What defined my career was constant learning. Over four decades of service passed quickly because the journey was fulfilling and intellectually engaging. If given another chance, I would choose to be a naval officer again.

Q9: CMDA: Sir, there's always been confusion about the overlap of responsibilities between the Indian Navy and the Coast Guard. Could you explain the division of responsibilities between them?

Ans: AKS: The Coast Guard is responsible for law enforcement, search and rescue, and pollution control within India's maritime zones up to 200 nautical miles from the baseline, as defined under the Maritime Zones of India Act, 1976. The Navy operates beyond these limits, focusing on defence, deterrence, and safeguarding national interests on the high seas. The two services complement each other across this vast maritime space.

Q10: CMDA: As we conclude, what message would you like to leave for the readers of CMDA Magazine?

Ans: AKS: My message is simple. Put service before self; this principle never goes out of relevance. Whatever field you choose, be a thorough professional and commit yourself to continuous learning,

because complacency is the greatest risk in a fast-changing world. As India grows, responsibility will grow with it. Technology will assist you, but values, judgment, and character will define you as a leader!



INTERNATIONAL NEWS

INDIA-OMAN TRADE-INVESTMENT TIES DEEPEN

About: India and Oman have signed the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) during PM Modi's state visit to Oman (18-19 Dec 2025). This is the first bilateral agreement that Oman has signed with any country since their agreement with the USA in 2006.



Highlights

- **FTA:** Negotiations for the agreement officially began in 2023. They also ease norms to promote trade in services and attract investments. India already has a similar agreement with the UAE, wef 2022.
- **Duty Free Access:** Oman has offered zero-duty access on 98.08% of its tariff lines, covering 99.38% of India's exports to Oman. India is offering tariff liberalization on 77.79% of its total tariff lines, which covers 94.81% of India's imports from Oman by value.
- **Exclusion from the CEPA:** To safeguard its interests, sensitive products have been kept in the exclusion category by India. It includes agricultural products, including dairy, tea, coffee, rubber, and tobacco; gold and silver bullion, jewellery; other labour-intensive products such as footwear, sports goods; and scrap of many base metals.
- **Enhanced Mobility:** A major highlight of the CEPA is the enhanced mobility framework for Indian professionals. Oman has offered wide-ranging commitments, including a notable increase in the quota for Intra-Corporate Transferees from 20% to 50%. Longer permitted duration of stay for Contractual Service Suppliers-extended from the existing 90 days to two years.
- **FDI:** The CEPA further provides for 100% FDI by Indian companies in major services sectors in Oman through commercial presence, expanding India's services industry to expand operations in the region.
- **Traditional Medicines:** Oman's commitment to Traditional Medicine extended across all modes of supply, representing a first such commitment made by any country. It will create a significant opportunity for India's AYUSH and wellness sectors to showcase their strength in the Gulf region.

India-Oman Ties

- **Diplomatic relations-** formalised in 1955 and elevated to a Strategic Partnership in 2008.

- **Trade Relations:** Oman is India's 28th largest trading partner in FY 2023-2024, with total bilateral trade rising from US\$ 6.70 billion in 2017-18 to US\$ 10.61 billion in 2024-25. India ranked as Oman's fourth largest source of non-oil imports and third largest destination for non-oil exports, underlining the diversification of economic ties beyond hydrocarbons.
- Investment flows have been similarly robust, with more than 6,000 India-Oman joint ventures operating in Oman. These ventures account for an estimated 7.5 billion US dollars in capital over time. Oman's cumulative FDI equity inflows into India between 2000 – 2025 amounted to \$ 605.57 million.
- **Defence Cooperation:** India and Oman conduct regular biennial bilateral exercises between all three services. Army exercise: Al Najah, Air Force exercise: Eastern Bridge, Naval Exercise: Naseem Al Bahr
- **Maritime Cooperation:** Oman is at the gateway of the Strait of Hormuz through which India imports one-fifth of its oil imports. India signed a pact with the country in 2018 to access the Duqm port of Oman.

Way Ahead - India-Oman economic relations are increasingly driven by diversification, sustainability and long-term strategic alignment. The CEPA is expected to significantly boost bilateral trade, generate employment, expand exports, strengthen supply chains, and open new avenues for deeper, long-term economic engagement between India and Oman.

PM MODI RECEIVES ETHIOPIA'S HIGHEST CIVILIAN HONOUR

Context: Prime Minister Narendra Modi was conferred with Ethiopia's highest civilian award, '**The Great Honour Nishan of Ethiopia**', by Ethiopian Prime Minister **Abiy Ahmed Ali** during his official visit to the country. The award recognizes his outstanding contribution to **strengthening bilateral relations** between India and Ethiopia, as well as India's growing engagement with the **African continent**. It symbolizes Ethiopia's appreciation for India's developmental partnerships in areas such as **capacity building, education, health, and technology**. The conferral also highlights Modi's vision for **South-South cooperation** and his efforts to deepen diplomatic, economic, and cultural ties with African nations. This honour places him among several global leaders recognized by Ethiopia for their role in promoting peace, cooperation, and mutual progress.



PM MODI VISITS JORDAN



Context: Prime Minister Narendra Modi concluded his two-day visit to Jordan on 16th of December after which he embarked on a visit to Ethiopia and Oman. The visit marks India's first full bilateral engagement with Jordan and comes as the two countries prepare to celebrate 75 years of diplomatic relations.

Highlights-

- Five MOUs were finalized, covering culture, renewable energy, water management, digital public infrastructure and a twinning arrangement between the historic sites of Petra and Ellora.
- India is Jordan's third-largest trading partner. PM Modi proposed enhancing bilateral trade to \$5 billion over the next five years. He also encouraged collaboration between Jordan's digital payment system and India's UPI.
- In FY 2023–24, total India-Jordan trade reached US\$ 2.875 billion, with India's exports to Jordan amounting to US\$ 1,465 billion.
- Jordan is a leading supplier of phosphates and potash fertilizers for India. Both sides also discussed investments in fertilizer production to meet India's growing demand, with Jordan being our important supplier of phosphates.

23rd INDIA RUSSIAN ANNUAL SUMMIT

Context: India and Russia held their 23rd annual bilateral summit at New Delhi, while also welcoming President Putin from 04 to 05 Dec, marking a major milestone-25 years of the Declaration of Strategic Partnership (2000).

Key Outcomes of the Visit-

- **Economic Programme 2030:** Both President Putin & PM Modi, welcomed the adoption of the Programme for the Development of Strategic Areas of India – Russia Economic Cooperation till 2030.
- **Trade Target:** Both Sides emphasised that addressing tariff and non-tariff trade barriers, for the timely achievement of the revised bilateral trade target of USD 100 billion by 2030.

- **Strategic Agreements Signed:** India and Russia exchanged sixteen agreements in areas related to defence, trade, economy, healthcare, academics, culture and media.

- **Free Trade Agreement (FTA) Push:** Both sides are working towards the early conclusion of a Free Trade Agreement with the Eurasian Economic Union.



- **Migration Cooperation:** India will soon be launching a free 30-day e-tourist visa and a 30-day Group Tourist Visa for Russian citizens.
- **Cooperation in Global and Multilateral Platforms:** Russia has decided to adopt the Framework Agreement to join the International Big Cat Alliance.

Significance of the Visit

- **Strategic Autonomy of India:** The visit underscores India's unwavering commitment to independent decision-making in foreign policy. By hosting the Russian President despite Western pressure, India signals its own geopolitical alignment independent of external pressure.
- **Defence Cooperation:** Russia still provides 60–70% of India's defence inventory, making the partnership vital for India's military readiness. Both sides agreed to reformulate defence cooperation by advancing joint R&D, co-development, and Make in India manufacturing of next-generation systems.
- **Economic and Trade Transformation:** Due to India's defence and energy imports from Russia, there has been a massive trade deficit that has prompted both governments to diversify cooperation. A 2030 Economic Cooperation Plan was adopted to expand collaboration in technology, manufacturing, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, and investment.
- **Energy Security and Strategic Supply Chains:** Russia remains India's leading crude oil supplier, providing substantial discounts despite Western sanctions. During the visit, President Putin assured India of consistent fuel supplies, though India exercised caution, noting that energy procurement decisions are based on changing market dynamics.
- **Long-Term Resilience and Adaptability:** Marking 25 years of the 2000 Strategic Partnership Declaration, the visit reflects continuity through global



shifts from the post-Cold War era to Russia's current isolation. This resilience suggests the relationship is grounded in mutual strategic interest.

How India–Russia Partnership Can Help Overcome US Tariff Challenges?

- **Energy Security and Cost**
- Advantage:** Russian crude oil imports at discounted rates help India keep its energy basket stable despite US penalties.
- **Market Diversification:** Russia (and the wider Eurasian region) offers alternative markets for Indian exports, reducing over-dependence on the US.
- Proposed India–Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) FTA can provide preferential access to a large market across Russia, Belarus, Armenia, Kazakhstan, and Kyrgyzstan
- **Connectivity & Logistics Advantage:** Projects like the INSTC, Chennai–Vladivostok maritime corridor, and Northern Sea Route can reduce transport time and costs for exports to Europe and Central Asia. This offsets the loss of competitiveness caused by US tariffs.
- **Trade in National Currencies & Payment Mechanisms:** Strengthening the Rupee–Rouble settlement systems shields India from dollar-dominated trade restrictions imposed by the US.
- **Defence & Strategic Tech Cooperation:** Russia continues to be a key supplier of defence technology and nuclear energy cooperation, areas where the US could impose restrictions.
- **Strategic Balancing in Geopolitics:** Deepening the Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership with Russia sends a signal to the US that India has viable alternatives. This can improve India's negotiating position in seeking tariff relief from the US.

Conclusion: The India–Russia partnership provides India with energy security, market diversification, and strategic autonomy at a time of tariff and geopolitical pressure from the US. By leveraging Russian ties, India can reduce vulnerability to American trade restrictions while continuing to pursue its long-term trade target of \$100 billion with Russia by 2030.

RELOS AGREEMENT RATIFIED

Introduction: Russia's lower house of parliament has ratified the Reciprocal Exchange of Logistic Support (Relos) Agreement with India. Relos is similar to logistics agreements India has signed with countries like the US, UK, Japan, Australia, France, Singapore, S Korea & Vietnam.

India–Russia Reciprocal Exchange of Logistics Support (RELOS) Agreement



- It is a bilateral military logistics pact that enables both countries' military aircraft, ships, and personnel to use each other's bases for refueling, maintenance, spare parts, training, joint exercises, humanitarian missions, and disaster relief.
- It streamlines logistics by reducing paperwork, ensuring quicker support, and allowing rolling settlement of costs.
- It also grants mutual access to each other's airspace and ports, which will provide India with strategic entry to the Arctic region along the Northern Sea Route, where Russia has an extensive military presence.
- For Russia, Relos offers access to Indian Ocean facilities, helping it maintain global reach despite Western sanctions and allowing power projection in Asia without costly overseas bases.

JOHANNESBURG HOSTS 20TH G20 SUMMIT

About: The 20th G20 Summit 2025, from 24-27 Nov, held in Johannesburg, South Africa, became the first-ever G20 summit hosted on the African continent. Under the theme “**Solidarity, Equality, Sustainability.**” The summit centred on Global South priorities.

Highlights

- **G20 Johannesburg Leaders' Declaration:** Member nations reached consensus on a 122-paragraph declaration including references to climate action, multilateral reform, and equitable global governance.
- **Spirit of Ubuntu and Multilateralism:** The declaration emphasises the African philosophy of Ubuntu (recognising shared global responsibility and interconnectedness).
- **UN Security Council Reform:** The declaration supports transforming the UNSC to reflect contemporary geopolitical realities, calling for expanded representation for underrepresented regions such as Africa, Asia-Pacific, and Latin America.



- **Condemnation of Terrorism:** The declaration unequivocally condemns terrorism in all forms and manifestations, reflecting India's longstanding position.

- **Expanded Climate Action**

Commitments: Members agreed to scale global climate finance toward a "billions-to-trillions" shift and

operationalise a more equitable transition under the Paris Agreement.

- **Empowerment of Women:** The declaration stressed women's empowerment, calling for removing barriers, ensuring equal participation in decision-making & recognising women as peace agents.
- **Debt Crisis and Global Financial Reform:** A Cost of Capital Commission was launched to reform global credit rating practices and reduce the unfair "African risk premium."
- **Africa's Growing Debt:** Also highlighted Africa's growing debt burden (now at USD 1.8 trillion), with over half its population living in countries spending more on debt interest than on public services.
- **Mission 300 :** An initiative led by the World Bank & African Development Bank to provide electricity to 300 million people in Sub-Saharan Africa by 2030.
- **Critical Minerals Framework:** Welcomed the G20 Critical Minerals Framework to secure sustainable value chains. Focus on investment in mineral exploration and local beneficiation in developing countries.
- **Youth & Gender Targets:** Adopted Nelson Mandela Bay Target to reduce the rate of youth Not in Employment, Education, or Training (NEET) by 5% by 2030. Committed to 25% gender parity in labour participation by 2030.
- **Troika:** The current G20 "troika" is Brazil (previous presidency), South Africa (current presidency), and the United States (next presidency).

Conclusion: The G20 Summit 2025 marked a pivotal moment for global governance, placing Africa and the wider Global South at the heart of multilateral priorities. The Johannesburg Declaration set the tone for a more equitable, secure, and sustainable world order.

NATIONAL NEWS

WINTER SESSION OF PARLIAMENT ADJOURNS SINE DIE AFTER 15 SITTINGS



Introduction: The Winter Session of Parliament, 2025, which commenced on 1st December, adjourned sine die on 19th December, spanned 15 sittings over 19 days. The session focused on critical legislative business, policy debates, and discussions reflecting India's vision of Viksit Bharat @2047, with emphasis on health, energy, rural employment, education, and governance reforms.

• Bills Introduced in Lok Sabha

1. The Manipur Goods and Services Tax (Second Amendment) Bill, 2025
2. The Central Excise (Amendment) Bill, 2025
3. The Health Security & National Security Cess Bill, 2025
4. The Repealing and Amending Bill, 2025
5. The Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025
6. The Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India Bill, 2025
7. The Appropriation (No 4) Bill, 2025
8. The Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Bill, 2025
9. The Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin): VB-G RAM G Bill, 2025.
10. The Securities Markets Code Bill, 2025



• Bills Passed by Both Houses:

1. **The Manipur Goods and Services Tax (Second Amendment) Bill, 2025** – Updates GST provisions in Manipur, replacing the Ordinance promulgated post-Monsoon Session.
2. **The Central Excise (Amendment) Bill, 2025** – Revises central excise procedures and rates for improved tax administration.
3. **The Health Security & National Security Cess Bill, 2025** – Imposes a cess to fund national security and public health initiatives.

4. **The Appropriation (No.4) Bill, 2025** – Provides authorization for govt expenditures under the Supplementary Demands for Grants 2025–26.
5. **The Repealing and Amending Bill, 2025** – Repeals obsolete laws and amends existing statutes for legal clarity and efficiency.
6. **The Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Bill, 2025** – Strengthens social security through amendments in insurance coverage frameworks.
7. **The Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India Bill, 2025** – Promotes nuclear energy development and safe utilisation for power, healthcare, agriculture, and research.



8. **The Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin): VB–G RAM G Bill, 2025** – Provides a statutory guarantee of 125 days of rural wage employment to empower rural households.

• **Special Discussions: 150th Anniversary of the National Song “Vande Mataram”:** Held in Lok Sabha on 8th December and Rajya Sabha on 9th–11th December; 146 MPs participated over 24 hours, 21

minutes in total.

• **Election Reforms:** Debated in Lok Sabha on 9th–10th; in Rajya Sabha on 11th, 15th–16th December; 119 MPs participated, totaling 23 hours 36 minutes.

• **Other Legislative Actions:** First batch of Supplementary Demands for Grants for 2025–26 discussed, passed, and Appropriation Bill enacted.

– Statutory Resolution adopting the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Amendment Act 2024 in Manipur was passed in the Rajya Sabha.

– Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill 2025, referred to the Jt Committee.

– Securities Markets Code Bill 2025, referred to the Standing Committee-Lok Sabha.

• **Productivity:** Lok Sabha recorded 110% productivity, while Rajya Sabha reached 121%, reflecting efficient legislative functioning.

Conclusion: The Winter Session of 2025 showcased Parliament’s proactive role in shaping India’s development agenda. From health and national security to rural employment, energy, education, and governance reforms, the session passed landmark legislation aligned with the Viksit Bharat vision @2047.

DEEPAVALI ENTERS UNESCO INTANGIBLE CULTURAL HERITAGE LIST 2025

Introduction: Deepavali, India's festival of lights, has been inscribed on the UNESCO Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity 2025, marking a major recognition of India's living cultural traditions.



Further Insights-

- The festival symbolises the victory of light over darkness and good over evil.
- It includes rituals, diya lighting, storytelling, crafts, and community celebrations across regions.
- UNESCO's recognition boosts India's cultural soft power and promotes the preservation of traditional practices.

Conclusion: Deepavali's inclusion highlights India's rich heritage and reinforces its global cultural presence. It also encourages the preservation of traditional practices for future generations.

INDIA ADVANCES GREEN MOBILITY WITH FIRST HYDROGEN-POWERED VESSEL AND TRAIN

Introduction: India has taken a decisive leap toward green and self-reliant transport with the launch of its first indigenous hydrogen fuel cell passenger vessel in Varanasi and the upcoming rollout of its first hydrogen-powered train. Together, these milestones mark a significant push toward sustainable mobility across inland waterways and railways under India's clean energy and Atmanirbhar Bharat vision.



Key Developments:

- India's first hydrogen fuel cell passenger vessel began commercial operations at Namo Ghat, Varanasi, showcasing hydrogen-based propulsion with zero emissions and water as the only byproduct.
- Built indigenously, the vessel uses a hybrid system combining hydrogen fuel cells, batteries, and solar power, setting a global benchmark in inland water transport.
- Parallely, Indian Railways has completed the development of its first hydrogen-powered train, fully designed and manufactured in India as a pilot project.

- The hydrogen train is the world's longest & most powerful on broad gauge, emitting only water vapour, demonstrating next-generation clean fuel technology.

Economic & Environmental Benefits:

- Both projects support de-carbonisation, reduce fossil fuel dependence, and enhance energy security.
- Boost sustainable tourism, decongest roads, and modernise public transport.
- The initiatives align with Maritime India Vision 2030 and Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, strengthening India's leadership in green transport innovation.



Conclusion: By simultaneously advancing hydrogen-powered waterways and railways, India is laying the foundation for a cleaner, future-ready transport ecosystem. These initiatives reaffirm India's commitment to sustainability, technological self-reliance, and climate-resilient growth in the Amrit Kaal era.

IGI AIRPORT BECOMES INDIA'S FIRST WATER-POSITIVE AIRPORT

Introduction: Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGI) has become India's first water-positive airport, replenishing more water than it consumes, while handling over 40 million passengers annually.



Further Insights-

- IGI uses 625 rainwater harvesting units, two 9-million-litre reservoirs, and a 16.6 MLD zero-liquid-discharge STP.
- Recycled water supports HVAC, irrigation, and toilets, while automated systems optimise usage.
- Recognition was conferred under the NITI Aayog–CII water neutrality framework.

Conclusion: IGI Airport sets a national benchmark for sustainable airport operations, enhancing climate resilience and promoting responsible water management.

BHARAT TAXI TO CHALLENGE RIDE-HAILING GIANTS WITH DRIVER-OWNED MODEL

Introduction: India's ride-hailing sector could change in January 2026, with the launch of **Bharat Taxi**. It is an Indian platform owned by drivers. Bharat Taxi

wants to compete with Ola, Uber, and Rapido by supporting drivers and not taking high commissions from them.

Key Features and Significance:

- Operated by Sahkar Taxi Cooperative, it follows a driver-owned cooperative model, making drivers stakeholders rather than gig workers.
- Pilot operations began in Delhi and parts of Gujarat in Dec25, with a full rollout in Delhi expected in Jan26.
- The platform claims over 1 lakh registered drivers, including car, auto-rickshaw, and bike taxi operators.
- Its zero-commission model allows drivers to retain 100% of fares initially, with any future fee redistributed as incentives.
- The app offers transparent pricing, multilingual support, real-time tracking, police-linked safety features, and Metro integration.
- Competitive pricing and minimal surge charges aim to ensure affordability and income stability.



Challenges: Competing with established aggregators and scaling the cooperative model sustainably remain key concerns. Also, driver overlap across platforms may limit exclusivity.

Conclusion: By blending cooperative ownership with technology-driven convenience, Bharat Taxi presents a compelling alternative in India's ride-hailing market.

INDIA IMPLEMENTS FOUR NEW CODES TO MODERNISE WORKFORCE PROTECTION

Introduction: GoI announced the official implementation of the four new Labour Codes, marking the most significant overhaul of the nation's labour framework since the 1950s. Effective from Nov 21, 2025, the Codes replace 29 complex and fragmented labour laws, ushering in an era of simplified compliance, universal social security, and expanded rights for workers, especially those in the gig and un-organised sectors. The move is being hailed by industry bodies as a decisive step toward creating a pro-worker, pro-employment, and globally competitive labour ecosystem. **The Four Pillars of Reform:** Framework is built upon 4 comprehensive codes:

1. **Code on Wages, 2019:** Standardises minimum wages and ensures timely payment across all industries.
2. **Industrial Relations Code, 2020:** Modernises rules around employment, service conditions, and dispute resolution.
3. **Code on Social Security, 2020:** Expands social security coverage to the unorganised, gig, and platform economies.
4. **Occupational Safety, Health, and Working Conditions (OSHC) Code, 2020:** Standardises national safety norms and welfare facilities



A Shift: From Fragmented to Formal: The previous regulatory structure, dating back to the pre-independence era, was criticised for being rigid and difficult to navigate. The new Codes address this by focusing on three core areas:

- **Simplifying Compliance:** Businesses will now adhere to a single registration, single licence, and single return system nationwide, significantly reducing the compliance burden previously associated with multiple, overlapping laws.
- **Formalisation of Employment:** The new regime mandates the issuance of appointment letters to all workers, eliminating the ambiguity and exploitation often faced by employees in the unorganised sector.

Benefits Across the Spectrum

- **Expanding the Safety Net:** Social security coverage has seen a massive jump, expanding from 19% of the workforce in 2015 to an estimated 64% following the

Worker Category	New Protection/Benefit
Contract Workers	Social security, health benefits and gratuity after 1 year.
Fixed-Term Employees	Equal wages and benefits as permanent staff.
Mine/Hazardous	Standardised national safety norms; Free annual health check-ups.
MSME Employees	Assured minimum wages; Double wages for overtime.
Migrant Workers	Portability of social security benefits across states.

full implementation of the Codes.

- **Revolutionary Gains for Gig and Women Workers:** The most transformative changes are seen in the protection extended to hitherto overlooked worker categories. Key provisions include:
For Women Employees: The Codes dismantle restrictive laws, promoting gender equality and inclusion. **Shifts & Sectors:** Permitted to work in **all shifts-sectors** with safety & consent. **Equal Pay:** **Equal pay for equal work** is legally mandatory. **Grievance Redressal:** Mandatory female representation in **grievance committees**.

To Conclude: Implementation of the four Labour Codes signals a definitive step by the Govt towards balancing ease of doing business with enhanced social protection, setting the stage for a future-ready and resilient Indian workforce.

SHAH INAUGURATES BANAS DAIRY'S BIO-CNG PLANT, BOOSTS WHITE REVOLUTION 2.0

Introduction: On Dec 6, Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation, **Amit Shah**, inaugurated Banas Dairy's new **Bio-CNG and Fertilizer Plant** in Gujarat. This project is central to the **White Revolution 2.0** vision to make India's dairy sector self-sufficient and profitable through cooperative models. Banas Dairy is now Asia's largest milk-producing cooperative, boasting a ₹24,000 crore annual turnover.



Highlights:

- **Circular Economy Model:** The plant converts cow dung and organic waste into renewable Bio-CNG fuel and organic fertilizer. This "waste-to-wealth" approach is projected to increase farmer income by at least 20%.
- **Expansion:** Shah laid the foundation for a new 150-ton milk powder plant and other high-value units (paneer, protein).
- **Empowerment:** He highlighted the role of rural women in managing the cooperative, with profits directly deposited into their accounts weekly.
- **National Plan:** White Revolution 2.0 is supported by 4 key initiatives, including the National Gokul Mission and the Animal Husbandry Infrastructure Development Fund (AHIDF).
- **Future Template:** Banas Dairy's model will be taught to 250 national dairy leaders in January 2026. New national cooperatives for seeds, organic products, and exports were also launched.

Conclusion: The inauguration of the Bio-CNG plant at Banas Dairy marks a decisive move toward a sustainable, circular, and cooperative-led rural economy. By converting waste into value, it delivers environmental gains and higher direct incomes for farmers, positioning Gujarat as a national model for empowering agriculture and dairy sectors.

NAVY COMMISSIONS MH-60R SEAHAWK HELICOPTERS SQN AT INS HANSA

Introduction -The Indian Navy has commissioned its second MH-60R Seahawk helicopter squadron, INAS 335 “Ospreys,” at INS Hansa, Goa, marking a major leap in naval aviation and maritime combat capability



Further Insights-

- With this induction, Indian Navy has fully operationalised its fleet of 24 MH-60R helicopters acquired from the USA.
- Designed for multi-role missions, this multi-role combat helicopter excels in anti-submarine warfare, anti-surface warfare, maritime surveillance, search and rescue, and logistics support. Equipped with advanced sensors such as dipping sonar, multi-mode radar, electronic warfare systems, and secure data links, the platform provides superior situational awareness against surface, sub-surface, and asymmetric threats.
- Replacing the ageing Sea King helicopters, the MH-60R significantly enhances India's blue-water operational reach. A five-year US-backed sustainment package further ensures high operational availability and long-term maintenance support within India.
- The squadron complements other naval aviation assets including P-8I aircraft, MQ-9B Sea Guardian drones, and upcoming Rafale-M fighters.

Conclusion-Induction of INAS 335 strengthens India's maritime deterrence, surveillance depth, and rapid response capability, reinforcing the Indian Navy's role as a dominant and technologically advanced force in the IPR.

HAL TEJAS MK-1A DELIVERY REVISION

HIGHLIGHTS PRODUCTION BOTTLENECKS

Introduction -Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) has revised its delivery schedule for the TEJAS MK-1A fighter and HTT-40 trainer aircraft for FY

2025–26, reflecting persistent supply chain and testing challenges, which have severely impacted India’s defence aerospace ecosystem, as highlighted by the CAS, from time to time.

Further Insights: HAL now plans to deliver only **five TEJAS MK-1A fighters** and **three HTT-40 trainers** by March 2026, down from the earlier target of 10 fighters & 12 trainers, indicating significant production stress.

- TEJAS MK-1A depends on **GE F404-IN20 engines**, whose delayed deliveries have disrupted assembly lines, slowing overall aircraft output.
- Mandatory **weapon firing and systems certification trials** for the MK-1A variant are still underway, extending timelines before formal induction into the IAF.
- The HTT-40 trainer programme has also faced manufacturing and testing hurdles, limiting HAL’s ability to scale deliveries as planned.
- The revisions highlight broader challenges within India’s defence manufacturing ecosystem, including vendor readiness, component availability, and testing infrastructure.
- Despite delays, both programmes remain central to the **Aatmanirbhar Bharat** initiative, aimed at reducing reliance on foreign platforms and strengthening indigenous aerospace capabilities.



Conclusion: The revised TEJAS MK-1A and HTT-40 delivery schedules underline the complexities of indigenous aircraft production. Resolving engine supply issues, accelerating trials, and strengthening the defence industrial ecosystem will be crucial for meeting future force modernisation goals.

TATA–LOCKHEED C-130J MRO HUB TAKES SHAPE

IN INDIA

Introduction -Tata Advanced Systems Limited (TASL) and Lockheed Martin have commenced work on India's first C-130J Super Hercules Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO) facility in Bengaluru, marking a key step towards defence self-reliance and long-term sustainment of IAF's strategic airlift fleet.



Further Insights To provide depot-level maintenance, structural repairs & avionics upgrades for IAF's C-130Js, reducing dependence on overseas MROs.

- Construction is planned to conclude by end-2026, with the first aircraft expected to be inducted for maintenance in early 2027—an ambitious target in India's defence infrastructure context.
- Beyond serving the IAF, the MRO is envisioned as a regional servicing hub for global C-130J operators, placing India on the international aerospace sustainment map.
- Success will depend on timely regulatory clearances, supply chain efficiency and development of a highly skilled workforce capable of handling complex heavy maintenance.
- Domestic MRO support is critical for improving aircraft availability, especially as C-130Js operate in extreme conditions like high-altitude airstrips, causing accelerated wear and tear.
- TASL's prior experience in C-130J manufacture provides a foundation, but transitioning to full-spectrum MRO will test execution capability.

Conclusion-If delivered on schedule and to global standards, the Bengaluru C-130J MRO facility can significantly enhance IAF's readiness and position India as a serious aerospace sustainment hub. Its true success, however, will be measured not at ground-breaking, but when the first aircraft rolls out-fully serviced and mission-ready.

EX SURYAKIRAN: STRENGTHENING INDIA–NEPAL

MILITARY SYNERGY

Introduction–India and Nepal conducted the 19th edition of **Exercise Suryakiran** at **Pithoragarh, Uttarakhand**. This annual battalion-level bilateral military exercise reflects the deep-rooted defence cooperation between the two neighbours and aims to enhance joint operational readiness in challenging terrains.



Further Insights– This **bilateral, annual military drill** is conducted alternately by the Indian Army and the Nepal Army, involving over **300 troops from each side**.

- Training modules emphasise **high-altitude warfare, jungle warfare, mountain operations, and counter-terrorism tactics**, aligning with the shared Himalayan geography.
- Troops practise **cordon-and-search operations, room intervention drills, surveillance techniques, and small-team combat tactics** to respond to insurgent and terrorist threats.
- The Exercise incorporates **modern surveillance systems, drones, secure communication equipment, medical evacuation procedures, and battlefield support technologies**.
- Soldiers exchange **best practices, survival techniques, tactical experiences & SOPs** drawn from real operational deployments.
- Previous edition (18th) was held in **Saljhandi, Nepal (2024–25)**, reinforcing its annual and reciprocal nature.

Conclusion–Exercise Suryakiran plays a vital role in reinforcing **India–Nepal military ties**, built on historical trust and shared security interests. By enhancing interoperability, tactical coordination, and mutual understanding, the exercise contributes significantly to **regional stability, border security cooperation, and collective preparedness** against evolving threats in the Himalayan region.

INDIAN ARMY ADOPTS BIO-DIESEL TO ADVANCE GREEN LOGISTICS

Introduction- Indian Army has formally introduced bio-diesel into its fuel supply chain, marking a major step toward sustainable and eco-friendly defence logistics. The initiative was launched in New Delhi by the VCOAS, on the 265th Corps Day of the Army Service Corps, in the presence of senior officials from BPCL.



Aligned with the National Biofuel Policy, the move aims to reduce carbon emissions & enhance long-term energy security. Along with the adoption of E-20 petrol from December 1, 2025, this initiative underscores the Army's commitment to clean energy, environmental stewardship, and innovation in operational logistics.

INDO-MALDIVIAN EXERCISE EKUVERIN



Introduction- The 14th edition of the Indo-Maldivian Joint Military Exercise **EKUVERIN 2025** recently concluded in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, reinforcing defence cooperation and operational synergy between India & Maldives in the IOR. “Ekuverin,” meaning *Friends* in Dhivehi, symbolises the strong camaraderie and trust between the two

Further Insights

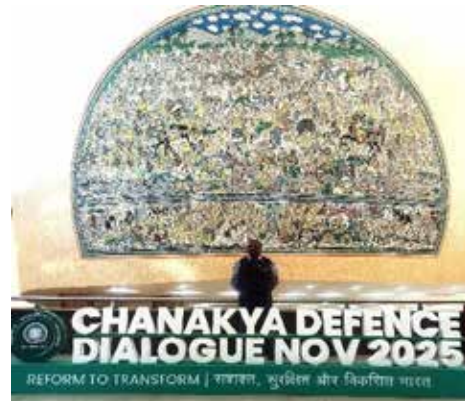
- Conducted from **2 to 15 Dec**, the Exercise involved troops from Army's **Garhwal Rifles** and the **Maldives National Defence Force (MNDF)**.
- Training focuses on **amphibious, littoral, jungle, semi-urban, and coastal operations**, reflecting realistic regional security challenges.
- Special emphasis is laid on **counter-insurgency and counter-terrorism drills**, including small-team tactics and joint mission planning.
- It also promotes **interoperability**, refinement of SOPs & exchange of best practices.

Conclusion-Ex EKUVERIN 2025 highlights the deepening India–Maldives defence partnership under India's *Neighbourhood First* policy, strengthening collective preparedness, regional stability & shared security interests in IOR.

CLAWS & INDIAN ARMY JOINTLY CONDUCT

CHANAKYA DEFENCE DIALOGUE

Introduction—Indian Army hosted the third edition of the Chanakya Defence Dialogue (CDD) 2025 in New Delhi on 27–28 November, held under the theme “**Reform to Transform: Sashakt, Surakshit aur Viksit Bharat.**” It served as a key platform to align military strategy with India’s long-term national security & development vision.



Further Insights -

- CDD 2025 brought together military leaders, policymakers, diplomats, academics, youth representatives and private-sector experts, reflecting a whole-of-nation approach to security.
- President Droupadi Murmu, inaugurating the event, emphasised preparedness across conventional warfare, peacekeeping, humanitarian assistance, cyber and space domains, stressing agility in an era of rapid technological disruption.



- Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi unveiled a three-phase transformation roadmap for the Indian Army leading up to 2047.

Phase 1 (by 2032): Organisational restructuring, doctrinal reforms and rapid induction of emerging technologies.

Phase 2 (by 2037): Consolidation into operational readiness and improved jointness and synergy.

Phase 3 (by 2047): A fully digitised, self-reliant, agile force aligned with India’s “Viksit Bharat” vision.

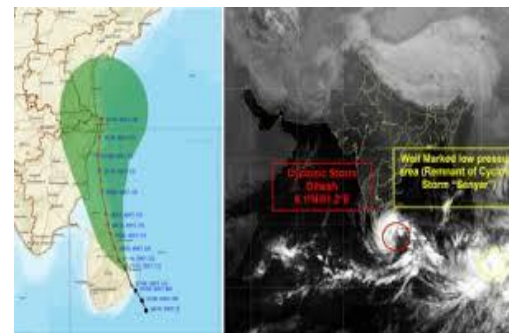
Conclusion-CDD 25'
underscored India's shift from incremental reform to strategic transformation. By linking military modernisation with national development goals, IA is positioning itself as a decisive pillar of a secure, strong and developed India by 2047.



SCIENCE - TECHNOLOGY, HEALTH & ENVIRONMENT NEWS

CYCLONE DITWAH DEVASTATES SRI LANKA & NEIGHBOURING NATIONS

Introduction: Cyclone Ditwah, which made landfall on 28th Nov, before moving back over the Bay of Bengal, unleashed one of the worst natural disasters in Sri Lanka's history, leaving over 600 people dead, as landslides and massive floods swept across the island. More than 5,000 homes were damaged, and thousands of acres of farmland were destroyed, severely impacting rural livelihoods.



Scale of Destruction-

- Torrential rainfall exceeding 150 mm in 24 hours, starting 28th Nov, triggered a deadly flood & subsequent landslide.
- The National Building Research Organization continued to warn residents in high-risk mountainous areas to evacuate.
- Hardest hit districts included Colombo, Gampaha, Puttalam & Munnar, Trincomalee & Batticaloa, while landslides in the central hill country devastated Kandy, Badulla & Matale.

Government Response-

- The military deployed thousands of troops for rescue, clearance and relief work. More than 1.8 lakh people were sheltered in 1094 Govt. run safety centres, even as Search & rescue efforts continued

- Reconstruction costs are estimated at \$6–7 billion, with the government promising generous compensation for affected families.

Regional Impact and IMF Support-

- The cyclone also devastated parts of coastal areas in Indonesia, Thailand, and Malaysia, claiming over 1,500 lives.
- SL requested additional IMF financial assistance, seeking a larger instalment from its ongoing bailout to strengthen future resilience.

DELAY IN SYNTACTIC FOAM DELIVERY SLOWS INDIA'S SAMUDRAYAAN MISSION



Introduction: India's ambitious Samudrayaan mission, which aims to send a three-member crew 6,000 metres below sea level, has hit a temporary roadblock. A delay in receiving syntactic foam cladding from France has pushed critical tests to mid-next year. The foam being used is developed in France and is undergoing tests in Norway before installation.

Why the Foam Matters: The foam is essential because it provides buoyancy, allowing the submersible to float; it must withstand extreme ocean pressure. Once the 500-metre dive is validated, the mission will move to its final stage. The titanium hull, being built by ISRO, will be shipped to Russia for pressure testing equivalent to 6,000-metre depth.

Testing Timeline Affected-

- Scientists at the National Institute of Ocean Technology (NIOT), Chennai, have already created a steel prototype of the submersible for preliminary simulations.
- Tests down to 100 metres are complete.
- A key 500-metre trial, initially planned for December 2025, has now been rescheduled to April next year, pending foam delivery.

Looking Ahead: The mission is crucial to India's future deep-sea exploration and plans for mining valuable resources from the ocean floor.

WHY GOA MAY SOON GET A TIGER RESERVE:

WHAT THE CEC FOUND-WHAT THE STATE SAYS

Introduction: The proposal for a tiger reserve in Goa has resurfaced after the SC's Central Empowered Committee (CEC) recommended that the State create one in a phased and community-sensitive manner. The issue has sparked debate because it combines conservation priorities, community rights, and conflicting government claims.

Why the CEC Pushed for a Tiger Reserve-The recommendation draws from earlier legal and ecological findings: In July 2023, the Bombay High Court ordered Goa to declare five protected areas-Mhadei, Bhagwan Mahavir, Bhagwan Mahavir National Park, Netravali & Cotigao-into a single tiger reserve. This was prompted by a petition following the poisoning of a tigress and her three cubs in 2020. It also asked the govt to prepare a Tiger Conservation Plan and settle the rights of forest-dwelling communities. NTCA had already endorsed these areas for tiger reserve status in 2016.

Goa Govt's Objections -The State argued that:

- Declaring the reserve may impact nearly one lakh people, though its own affidavit later reduced this figure to 6,000 people across 33 villages.
- Goa has no resident tiger population, only transient animals.



However, this contradicted its 2018 submission to a water tribunal claiming evidence of resident tigers and ecological linkage to Karnataka's Kali and Bhimgad reserves. These inconsistencies led the Supreme Court to ask the CEC to assess the situation on the ground.

CEC's Phased Plan: To reduce community fears, it suggests a stepwise plan:

- **Phase 1:** Core Zone (296.7 sq. km)
 - ✓ Netravali Wildlife Sanctuary – ~50 households
 - ✓ Cotigao Wildlife Sanctuary – ~41 households
- **Phase 2:** Buffer Zone
 - ✓ Northern Bhagwan Mahavir Sanctuary – 9 households
 - ✓ Bhagwan Mahavir National Park – 2 households
 - ✓ This zone directly connects to Karnataka's Kali Tiger Reserve, strengthening a shared tiger landscape.

Why Tiger Reserve Status Matters?

- Brings greater funding for conservation and scientific monitoring.
- Creates core zones (inviolable) and buffer zones (regulated use).
- Ensures community rights, with only voluntary relocation allowed.

How India Declares a Tiger Reserve: State proposes the area to NTCA, it evaluates ecological potential; Ministry of Environment approves; State issues prelim & final notifications under the Wildlife Protection Act, Section 38V.

Conclusion: Goa's decision will shape the future of Western Ghats conservation and the rights of its forest communities.

AIDS AND TB FIGHT: TAMIL NADU CONTINUES TO LEAD INDIA'S PUBLIC HEALTH BATTLE

Introduction: On World AIDS Day (1st Dec), India's journey in combating HIV/AIDS and Tuberculosis (TB) offers a powerful reminder of how strong public health systems can transform outcomes. At the heart of this success story is Tamil Nadu, a state pioneering decentralised, community-based interventions that later shaped national policy.



India's Early AIDS Challenge

- When HIV emerged in the 1980s–1990s, it triggered a global scare.
- In India, the virus spread mainly through unprotected heterosexual contact and needle sharing, causing widespread immune suppression and opportunistic infections—especially tuberculosis.

The AIDS–TB Connection—TB remains the leading infection among HIV-positive individuals, causing nearly 25% of AIDS-related deaths. With India contributing a quarter of the world's TB and MDR-TB burden, integrated care is essential.

Tamil Nadu's Leadership in TB Elimination: Its strategy includes:

- Digital tools for patient tracking and screening
- Unified AIDS–TB control units
- Community-based testing and awareness
- Support from ICMR–NIE for rapid diagnosis and nutrition programmes

National Lessons

- Integrated HIV–TB surveillance improves infrastructure use
- Autonomous health societies increase accountability
- Community engagement & digital tracking strengthen epidemic control

Conclusion: Tamil Nadu’s data-driven, decentralised, and community-led model not only helped curb HIV but now serves as a roadmap for India’s goal of ***TB-Mukt Bharat by 2025***.

DoT WITHDRAWS SANCHAR SAATHI PRE-INSTALLATION ORDER AFTER PUBLIC OUTCRY



Introduction: The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) has withdrawn its controversial directive asking smartphone manufacturers to pre-install the

The Sanchar Saathi app on all devices starting next year. The decision follows strong backlash from civil society, digital rights groups & opposition parties over concerns of forced govt software being embedded in

user devices.

Why the Mandate Was Rolled Back?

- After days of defending the move, DoT reversed course, citing a surge in voluntary downloads of Sanchar Saathi following the public debate.
- The app helps users identify fraudulent SIMs, block lost phones, and report cyber scams.
- DoT said it aimed to make the app accessible to “**less aware citizens**”.
- With downloads rising sharply, the government argued there was now “no need” for compulsory installation.
- Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia stressed in Parliament that the app had already helped disconnect 1.5 crore fraudulent mobile connections and trace 26 lakh stolen phones, but also acknowledged that “**public support**” was essential.

Part of a Series of New Regulatory Orders -The withdrawn order was one of the directives issued after DoT amended Telecom Cyber Security Rules, 2024:

1. WhatsApp-Linked Restrictions

- Accounts must be used only on devices containing the registered SIM.
- WhatsApp Web sessions must auto-logout every six hours.

2. Fraud Prevention Integration

- Messaging & social media platforms must adopt DoT's Financial Fraud Risk Indicator.
- Accounts linked to suspended mobile numbers be imdtly deactivated.

To Sum Up: A Broader Push for Digital Security -All these orders stem from the DoT's AI and Digital Intelligence Unit, which focuses on SIM fraud, illegal telecom setups, and coordination with RBI on financial cybercrime. The episode highlights the tension between digital security goals and citizens' privacy expectations-calling for transparent regulation.

CHINA'S REUSABLE ROCKET TEST ENDS IN BOOSTER EXPLOSION

Introduction: On 03 Dec, China's commercial space sector faced a setback when LandSpace's Zhuque-3 rocket failed in its attempt to re-land its first-stage booster. The rocket successfully reached orbit, but its reusable booster-a technology crucial for cutting launch costs- crashed during the landing attempt. Experts say the attempt was "90% successful", with only an engine ignition issue causing the failure.

What Went Wrong During the Landing?

- LandSpace said an "anomaly" occurred during engine ignition in the landing phase, preventing a soft touchdown on the recovery pad.
- Booster debris fell at the edge of the designated zone.
- The company will conduct a comprehensive technical review.
- Despite the failure, the booster descended close to the target, suggesting significant progress.



Why This Test Still Matters?

- The attempt places LandSpace at the forefront of China's rapidly expanding private space industry, which aims to compete with SpaceX.
- Reusable rockets drastically reduce launch costs and turnaround time.
- Are strategically important as space has military-defence capabilities.
- A decade ago, SpaceX pioneered reusable boosters- now it dominates the global launch market.

China's Race to Compete with SpaceX -LandSpace has ambitious plans:

- Launch missions for China's Tiangong Space Station from 2026.
- Build on its earlier success — the world's first methane-liquid oxygen orbital launch in 2023.

Looking Ahead: Even with this failed landing, China's commercial space industry has reached a critical turning point. As analysts note, rapid testing, failure, and iteration are essential steps toward mastering reusable rocket technology — and closing the gap with global leaders.

INDIA EXPANDS RAMSAR FOOTPRINTS: 2 NEW WETLANDS ADDED, TOTAL NOW 96



India has strengthened its commitment to wetland conservation by adding two new sites-Siliserh Lake (Rajasthan) & Kopra Jalashay (Chhattisgarh)-to the Ramsar List of Wetlands, taking the country's total to 96 Ramsar sites. This addition highlights India's growing role in global wetland conservation.

About the Ramsar List

- ✓ **Genesis:** Established under the Ramsar Convention (1971, Iran)
- ✓ **Global Reach:** 90% of UN members (incl India), Contracting Parties
- ✓ **Significance:** Ramsar designation grants wetlands national recognition and international importance
- ✓ **Criteria:** Sites to meet 1 of the 9 ecological criteria set by Convention.

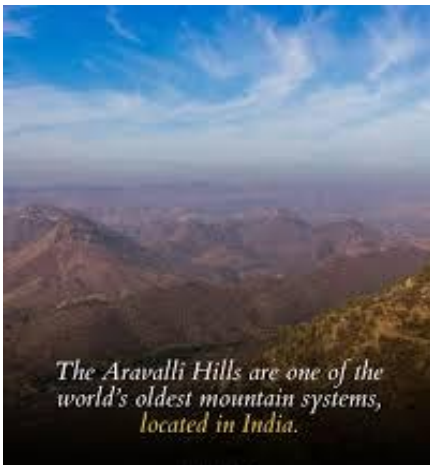
Siliserh Lake, Rajasthan

- ✓ **Location:** Alwar District
- ✓ **Origin:** A human-made wetland, created in 1845 AD by Maharaja Vinay, by constructing a bund across a tributary of the Ruparel River
- ✓ **Biodiversity:** Egyptian Vulture, Black Stork, Tiger, Indian Pangolin, Leopard, Sambar

Kopra Jalashay, Chhattisgarh

- ✓ **Location:** Bilaspur District
- ✓ **Hydrology:** Reservoir in the upper catchments of the Mahanadi River
- ✓ **Ecological Features:** Large open water area with shallow, nutrient-rich backwaters
- ✓ **Biodiversity:** Bar-headed Goose, Egyptian Vulture, Spotted Eagle
- ✓ **Threats:** Siltation, invasive non-native species, surrounding agriculture.

HOW TO PROTECT THE ARAVALLI RANGE



The Aravalli Range, India's oldest mountain system, has come under renewed judicial focus after the Supreme Court recently settled on a uniform definition of the Aravalli hills & paused the grant of fresh mining leases across Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan & Gujarat. This move aims to address decades of ecological degradation caused largely by unregulated mining.



Ecological and Strategic Significance -

- ✓ Nearly two billion years old, act as a natural ecological barrier, preventing the eastward spread of the Thar Desert into the Indo-Gangetic plains.
- ✓ The range plays a vital role in climate regulation, biodiversity conservation, and groundwater recharge.
- ✓ Stretching over 650 km from Delhi to Gujarat, it is the source of rivers such as the Chambal, Sabarmati, and Luni.
- ✓ Rich in minerals like limestone, marble, granite, zinc, copper, gold, and tungsten, making them vulnerable to overexploitation.
- ✓ Excessive quarrying over 40 years has resulted in air pollution, groundwater depletion, and habitat loss.

Judicial and Government Action on Mining

- ✓ Since the 1990s, regulations restricted mining, but violations persisted.
- ✓ In 2009, the SC imposed a blanket mining ban in parts of Haryana.
- ✓ In May 2024, the Court halted new mining leases and tasked the Central Empowered Committee (CEC) for a detailed review.
- ✓ CEC recommended scientific mapping, macro-level environmental impact assessments, a ban in ecologically sensitive zones, including wildlife corridors and aquifer recharge areas. Same adopted on Nov 25.
- ✓ In June 2025, GoI launched *-Aravalli Green Wall Project*, for greening a 5-km buffer zone across 29 districts, aimed at land restoration by 2030.

Why a Uniform Definition Was Needed: States were using inconsistent criteria to define the Aravallis. To resolve this, the SC formed an expert committee that ultimately defined the range as hills above 100 metres. While concerns were raised about excluding smaller formations, SC accepted the definition as more inclusive and workable.

The Way Forward: SC directed the **preparation of a Management Plan for Sustainable Mining (MPSM)** to: Identify no-mining zones; Allow strictly regulated mining in limited areas; Assess ecological carrying capacity; Ensure restoration and rehabilitation. The protection of the Aravalli's now hinges on effective implementation, ensuring harmony between development and ecological survival.

MANAGEMENT & ECONOMIC NEWS

WHY IS ₹ FEELING THE HEAT RIGHT NOW

Introduction: Indian Rupee slipping into the nineties against the dollar has become the big headline today. For students planning to go abroad, it means tighter budgets. For travellers, it means costlier holidays. And for businesses that rely on imported goods, it means their expenses just shot up. But the question everyone's asking is simple, why is the rupee suddenly looking so weak?

The Global Escape to the Dollar-

A big part of the story begins outside India. Global investors have been pulling money out of emerging markets and running back to the safest asset they know, the US dollar. Whenever foreign funds exit Indian markets, they sell rupees and buy dollars. That pushes up dollar demand and drags the rupee down. It's a pattern that plays out every time global uncertainty flares up.



This year has seen that in full swing. Slowing global growth, geopolitical worries and shifting interest rate expectations in the US have all pushed investors into “risk-off” mode. And the rupee ended up as collateral damage.

Our Import Habit isn't Helping-



India imports a lot-crude oil, electronics, machinery, metals, chemicals, you name it. Every importer needs dollars to pay international suppliers. So, when the dollar strengthens, the entire import bill rises. Add oil prices that have been anything but stable and the pressure on the rupee intensifies. It's a cycle that feeds on itself. Costlier

dollars mean costlier imports. Costlier imports mean more demand for \$. And more demand for dollars means a weaker rupee.

Exports Aren't Picking Up the Slack-

Usually, a weaker rupee boosts exports because Indian goods become cheaper abroad. But global demand has been soft. Tariffs in key markets haven't helped either. So even though the rupee is weaker, exporters aren't getting the bump they normally would. One of the natural cushions for currency depreciation just isn't kicking in this time.

And the RBI Isn't Defending a Number -

Everyone wonders why the RBI doesn't simply step in and hold the rupee up.

The truth is, it *does* intervene, but selectively — only to prevent panic. It doesn't want to burn through foreign exchange reserves just to keep the rupee fixed at a particular level. Letting the currency move slowly and naturally often makes more sense than defending a symbolic number. So, the drop feels sharp, but it's not uncontrolled. It's more like a guided slide.

So, What Does This Mean for Ordinary People?

Overseas education becomes pricier. Travel budgets inflate. Imported items from phones to appliances quietly edge up in cost. Companies that depend on imported materials will eventually pass the higher costs to consumers. Inflation doesn't rise overnight, but the pressure builds gradually.

And yet, this isn't a crisis. Many fast-growing economies see gradual depreciation over time as they import more and integrate deeper with global markets. The rupee isn't collapsing; it's adjusting to global realities.

The coming months will depend on US interest rates, oil prices and how global investors feel about risk. If things stabilise, the rupee could find its footing again. If volatility continues, it may stay under pressure.

For now, the takeaway is simple, the rupee's fall isn't about domestic weakness. It's about global forces flexing their muscles. And India, like many economies in a turbulent world, is navigating the ripple effects.

INDIA JUST POSTED ITS FASTEST GROWTH IN 6 QUARTERS

Introduction: India's latest GDP numbers landed and they surprised almost everyone. In the quarter ending September, the economy grew at eight-point two percent. That is the fastest pace in six quarters and well above what most economists had pencilled in. And while global trade is still shaky and the world

economy is wobbling, India seems to have found a way to keep marching forward.



So, what exactly powered this growth spurt?

The engines behind the acceleration

The biggest push came from manufacturing, which expanded sharply thanks to steady demand and better operating conditions. Services, construction and even financial activities pitched in and created a broad base of momentum. It was not a one-sector wonder.

On the consumption side, households opened their wallets again. Private consumption picked up smoothly and helped balance out the drag from soft exports. Investments also held steady as both government capital spending and private fixed capital formation supported demand. Domestic activity essentially cushioned the blow from weak global trade.

There was also a quieter factor at play. Prices were relatively tame during the quarter, which meant inflation did not steal too much of the headline number. When inflation is low, the real growth figure looks stronger and that partly explains the upside surprise.

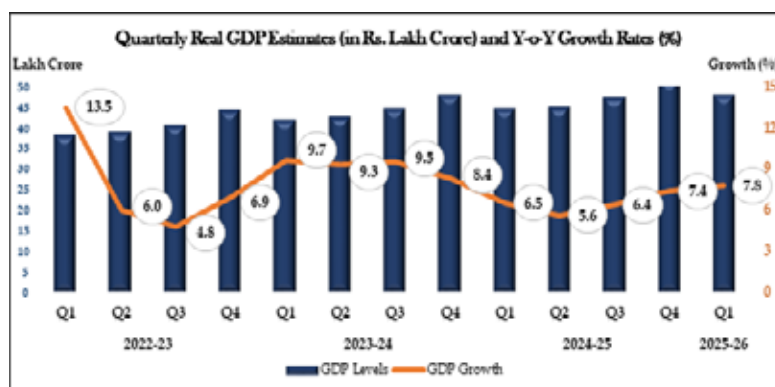
Why the timing matters?

This burst of growth comes when the global economy is dealing with uncertainty ranging from new trade barriers to slowing demand. In that environment, a strong domestic performance is more than a feel-good headline. It signals that India is relying less on global demand and more on internal resilience.

A strong print like this also has real-world implications. It usually reflects better employment prospects, higher consumption and a more confident business environment. It allows policymakers a little more breathing room too, because strong output acts like a shock absorber against global volatility.

But not everything is perfect

Economists have already flagged a couple of warning signs. Some of the strengths may be temporary because low inflation and statistical effects have pumped up the real numbers. Private investment is still not



firing on all cylinders. Exports remain under pressure. And global conditions are far from stable.

So, while the headline number is impressive, the underlying story is still mixed. The next few quarters will show whether the economy can sustain this rhythm without help from a soft inflation base or festive demand.

What to watch now:

The key questions are simple. Will domestic demand stay firm now that the festive quarter is over? Will private investment finally pick up? And can exports recover even as global conditions remain tricky?

If the answers are positive, India could continue to outperform expectations. If not, the 8.2% may end up looking like a temporary peak. Either way, the next few months will reveal how much of this growth is built on solid ground and how much was the perfect combination of timing and circumstance.

THE YEN THAT GOT TOO CHEAP



The Japanese yen is hovering near 155 against the US dollar, which is one of its weakest levels in years. At first glance, it sounds like a win for Japan's exporters. A cheaper currency usually means Japanese cars, electronics and machinery become more affordable globally and profits earned abroad look bigger when converted back into yen.

But this time, the weakness is no blessing. It is turning into a pressure point for the entire economy.

Why a Weak Yen is Hurting Japan?

A falling yen makes imports costlier. Japan depends heavily on imported food, fuel and raw materials. So every extra yen spent on these necessities pushes household budgets higher and raises inflation. And this inflation is not because demand is booming, but because imports are expensive. That means people are paying more without consuming more.

Japan's deeper structural problems add to the strain. An ageing population, low productivity growth and a tight labour market are keeping demand subdued. So



even with a weak currency, the expected export boom is not materialising in a meaningful way. Instead, the country is dealing with higher living costs and slower real economic improvement.

Why Economists Call it a Ticking Time Bomb: Many analysts now believe the yen is far weaker than what Japan's underlying economic fundamentals justify. When markets think an asset is mispriced, the correction can be sudden and violent.

If investors who hold large dollar yen positions decide the trade has gone too far, they may start unwinding quickly. That can cause the yen to surge abruptly. This kind of snapback has happened before and it tends to rattle global markets. A fast-rising yen can hurt Japanese exporters, disrupt global trade and shake bond and equity markets across Asia and beyond.

Why the World Should Pay Attention?

A currency as central to global finance as the yen does not move in isolation. A sudden reversal can unsettle carry trades; shift investor flows away from emerging markets, move global bond yields and even distort commodity pricing. For countries like India that import machinery and capital goods from Japan or have investors exposed to yen related trades, a major correction can create ripple effects at home too. In short, the Yen did not fall in a healthy way and it may not rise in a healthy way either. That imbalance is why many analysts are calling it a ticking time

SPORTS NEWS

SUMMER DEAFLYMPICS: INDIAN SHOOTERS ON FIRE

Introduction: The 2025 Summer Deaflympics in Tokyo marked nearly a century of the event since it began in Paris in 1924.

India sent its biggest-ever squad, 73 athletes across 11 sports and delivered one of its best performances. The country finished with 20 medals, including 9 gold, 7 silver and 4 bronze. Shooting stole the spotlight, with Indian shooters producing three world records and winning 16 medals on their own, making them the real stars of India's campaign.





Nations at the Top:

Ukraine secured the top position with a total of 100 medals. The USA ranked second with 36 medals. Japan followed in third place with 51 medals. India stood at sixth rank, earning a total of 20 medals. The shooting range became India's strongest stage with three new world-record wins.

- **Dhanush Srikanth** – Gold, Men's 10m Air Rifle (**WR**)
- **Anuya Prasad** – Gold, Women's 10m Air Pistol (**WR**)
- **Pranjali Prashant Dhumal** – Gold, Women's 25m Pistol (**WR**)

The Tokyo Deaflympics concluded with competitive performances across sports and strong participation from nations worldwide.

INDIA WINS BID TO HOST 2030 CW GAMES

Introduction: India is set to host the **2030**

Commonwealth Games in **Ahmedabad, Gujarat**, marking the country's return as a major multi-sport organizer after 20 years. The decision was confirmed in November 2025, during CW Sport's General Assembly in Glasgow, where Ahmedabad was selected ahead of Abuja, Nigeria. The centenary edition is expected to feature **15–17 sports**, with T20 cricket and triathlon currently under review.



LAKSHYA SEN'S SUPER 500 TITLE AT SYDNEY



India's Lakshya Sen closed the season on a strong note by winning the 2025 Australian Open Super 500 Badminton title in Sydney, defeating Japan's Yushi Tanaka in straight games 21–15, 21–11. The 38-minute final saw Sen in complete control from the opening rallies, marking his 3rd Super 500 title & 1st championship win of the year. Despite missing out on a place in the World Tour Finals, this win gives Sen a timely boost in form and ranking as he ends the year with a solid title to his name.

INDIA CLAIMS GOLD AT SQUASH WORLD CUP

India created history by winning the gold medal at the Squash World Cup, marking a landmark moment in the country's squash journey. Playing on home soil, the Indian team delivered composed and consistent performances to defeat Hong Kong 3–0 in the final and clinch the title. The triumph, achieved by **Joshna Chinappa, Abhay Singh, Anahat Singh and Velavan Senthilkumar**, marked India's first-ever Squash World Cup gold and underlined the nation's steady rise in international squash.



The latest edition was held in Chennai, India, bringing world-class squash to the home. The Squash World Cup, introduced in the 1970s, is one of the sport's most prestigious international team tournaments, featuring top squash nations in a knockout format.

UZBEK PRODIGY BECOMES YOUNGEST FIDE WC CHAMPION

Introduction: In this high-pressure setting, Uzbekistan's rising star Javokhir Sindarov made history by becoming the youngest FIDE World Cup champion at the age of 19, defeating China's Wei Yi in a tense tiebreak, after two classical draws.



Inside the Tiebreak Battle:

Game 1: Sindarov opened with 1.d4; Wei Yi erred at move 30, but the game ended in a draw.

Game 2: The Italian Opening shaped the decisive battle, Wei Yi missed a winning idea in time trouble and later blundered, giving Sindarov a decisive attack & title.

The International Chess Federation (FIDE), founded in 1924, introduced the FIDE Chess World Cup in 2000 as a global knockout event. The 2025 edition in Goa brought together 206 players and delivered several intense matches, setting the stage for a memorable final

To Sum Up: The 2025 FIDE World Cup concluded smoothly in Goa, showcasing Indian players such as **Arjun Erigaisi and Vidit Gujrathi** delivering notable performances, while the tournament overall featured high-level competition and a historic finish.

INDIA CLINCHES BRONZE AT MEN'S JR HOCKEY WORLD CUP



Introduction: India's junior men finished their campaign with the bronze medal after a dramatic comeback against Argentina. Trailing 0–2 until the start of the fourth quarter, India turned the match around, scoring four unanswered goals to win 4–2. The result underlined the team's fighting spirit and secured a podium finish on home soil. However, Germany lifted their record-extending eighth Junior World Cup title, defeating

Spain in the final via a penalty shoot-out after the match ended (1–1) in regulation time.

The 2025 edition, hosted in Chennai and Madurai, India, was historic, featuring 24 teams for the first time and delivering several high-intensity matches.

In women's hockey, India finished 10th after losing the 9th–10th place playoff match against Spain (2–1) at the FIH Hockey Junior Women's World Cup 2025 in Santiago.

Meanwhile, Netherlands continued their dominance by defeating Argentina (2–1) in the final to lift a record 6th title, also completing a third consecutive championship. Belgium secured the bronze medal after a convincing win over China.

PAKISTAN BEATS INDIA-LIFTS U19 ASIA CUP

Introduction: The ACC Under-19 Cricket Asia Cup, first held in 1989, is a key tournament in Asian youth cricket, designed to identify and develop future international players. The 2025 edition was played at the ICC Academy Ground, Dubai, bringing together top Under-19 teams from the region.



In the final, held on 21 December 2025 in Dubai, Pakistan U19 defeated India U19 by 191 runs to claim the title. Pakistan posted a commanding total of 347/8, powered by a breathtaking 172 by Sameer Minhas, while India was bowled out for 156 in 26.2 overs, giving Pak their second U19 Asia Cup crown. India's batsmen struggled for consistency on the final day despite earlier wins in the tournament, and their bowlers were unable to contain Pakistan's batting lineup.

NITIN PUTS INDIA ON GLOBAL DARTS MAP

Introduction: The Professional Darts Corporation (PDC), formed in 1992, organises the PDC World Darts Championship, which has been held annually since 1994. Played every year at the iconic Alexandra Palace in London since 2008, the tournament is regarded as the most prestigious event in professional darts, featuring the world's top-ranked players in a knockout format.



At the 2026 PDC World Darts Championship, India's Nitin Kumar created history by becoming the first Indian to win a match at the tournament. Kumar defeated the Dutch, Richard Veenstra (3–2) in a closely fought first-round match, showing strong finishing under pressure to advance to the last 64. His victory marked a major milestone for Indian darts on the global stage. Nitin Kumar's breakthrough represents a significant step forward for Indian darts and signals the sport's expanding global reach beyond its traditional boundaries.

WRESTLER VINESH PHOGAT ANNOUNCES COMEBACK-EYES ON LOS ANGELES 2028



Indian wrestler 31-year-old, Vinesh Phogat, has ended her retirement and announced a return to competitive wrestling, with her sights set on the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. Phogat, who had stepped away from the sport after being disqualified from the Paris 2024 Olympic final in the women's 50 kg category due to missing the weight limit by a small margin, shared her decision to resume training and competition following an 18-month break.

JHARKHAND SCRIPTS T20 GLORY AT SYED MUSHTAQ ALI TROPHY 2025

The Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (**India's premier domestic T20 tournament since 2006–07**) concluded with a historic final in 2025, where Jharkhand defeated Haryana by 32 runs to claim their maiden title.

Top performers made the difference in the final. Ishan Kishan led Jharkhand with a match-winning century, scoring 100 runs in just 49 balls, while Kushagra played a quick and impactful knock of 81 off 38 balls. With the ball, Sushant and his teammates bowled out Haryana for 193 in 19.3 overs.



Haryana ended the tournament as runners-up after a consistent and disciplined campaign. Ishan Kishan's strong performance throughout the tournament once again showed how important domestic T20 performances are for earning a place in the national team.

INDIA SHINES AT FEI ASIAN EQUESTRIAN CHAMPIONSHIPS 2025



Ashish Limaye created history by becoming the first Indian rider to win a gold medal in the 2nd edition of the championship was held in Pattaya, Thailand, in December 2025. India put up a strong performance, winning five medals (1 gold and 4 silver). Host nation Thailand finished on top of the table with seven medals, including three golds and four bronzes.

The Fédération Équestre Internationale (FEI) is the world body governing equestrian sports. It was founded in 1921 in Paris to set common rules for Olympic horse sports like Jumping, Dressage, and Eventing.

A QUIZ TO RATTLE YOUR BRAINS

International

1. Which country hosted the first leg of PM Modi's three-nation tour on December 15-16, 2025 to strengthen strategic ties?
a) Ethiopia b) Jordan c) Oman d) UAE
2. Russia signed the RELOS military cooperation agreement with India into federal law following President Putin's visit in 2025, on which dates?
a) Dec 4-5 b) Dec 10-11 c) Dec 15-16 d) Dec 20-21
3. In the Lowy Institute's Asia Power Index 2025, which nation retained the top position while India secured 3rd rank?
a) China b) Japan c) USA d) Australia

4. Which group of major economies (including India, China, Russia) opposed binding phase-out language at the recent climate talks in December 2025?
a) G7 nations b) BRICS+ c) EU bloc d) ASEAN group
5. Oxford University Press named which term as Word of the Year 2025 amid rising online manipulation trends?
a) Rage Bait b) Deepfake c) Climate Doom d) AI Overlord

National Affairs (India)

6. PM Modi chaired the 60th All India Conference of DGsP & IGsP in which city during November 28-December 2025?
a) New Delhi b) Raipur c) Jaipur d) Lucknow
7. India was re-elected to the UNESCO Executive Board in 2025 for the term starting?
a) 2026-29 b) 2025-29 c) 2026-30 d) 2027-31
8. Supreme Court approved mining in Aravalli Hills based on the new eco-definition released on?
a) Dec 15 b) Dec 18 c) Dec 21 d) Dec 22
9. PM Modi recently launched the Ashwagandha postal stamp and commissioned the ICG ship 'Amulya' on?
a) Dec 20 b) Dec 21 c) Dec 22 d) Dec 23
10. India's first 'Generation Z' Post Office opened in which Union Territory amid a digital push?
a) Jammu & Kashmir b) Ladakh c) Andaman & Nicobar d) Puducherry

Defence & Security

11. India and UAE launched which joint military exercise in December 2025?
a) Desert Cyclone II b) Garuda Shakti c) Mitra Shakti d) Yudh Abhyas
12. Exercise Harimau Shakti 2025 between India and Malaysia was held in which Indian state?
a) Rajasthan b) Uttarakhand c) Maharashtra d) Tamil Nadu
13. Joint naval Exercise 'Ektah' 2025 was conducted between India and?
a) Maldives b) Sri Lanka c) Bangladesh d) Nepal
14. India hosted the COP30 Pre-Summit Meet in New Delhi in December 2025, focusing on?
a) Climate finance b) Nuclear disarmament c) Trade barriers d) Cyber security
15. IWAI signed an MoU worth over Rs 6000 crore to modernize Ganga waterways with which state?
a) Uttar Pradesh b) Bihar c) Jharkhand d) West Bengal

Science & Technology

16. ISRO launched which communication satellite in December 2025 to boost high-speed connectivity in remote areas?
a) GSAT-31A b) GSAT-32 c) NISAR d) SpaDeX

17. Which five-year strategy document for financial inclusion was released by the RBI, covering 2025-30?

- a) NSFI b) UPI 2.0 c) Digital Rupee Plan d) FinInc-30

18. CRISIL raised India's GDP growth forecast for FY26 to what percent after strong Q2 data?

- a) 6.5% b) 7% c) 7.5% d) 8%

19. The National Education Commission ranked which state as top in the School Learning Index 2025?

- a) Kerala b) Tamil Nadu c) Delhi d) Himachal Pradesh

20. RBI introduced which framework in December 2025 to secure UPI, cards and wallets against cyber-fraud?

- a) Unified Digital Payment Security b) Cyber Shield 2025 c) FinSecure Protocol d) UPI Guard

Sports

21. India won the Squash World Cup 2025 title hosted for the third time in which city (Dec 10-14)?

- a) Chennai b) Mumbai c) New Delhi d) Hyderabad

22. Which shuttler won the BWF World Tour Finals 2025 women's singles title in Hangzhou?

- a) An Seyoung (South Korea) b) Chen Yufei (China) c) Tai Tzu-ying (Taiwan) d) PV Sindhu (India)

23. The 33rd Southeast Asian Games (SEA Games) 2025 began on December 9 in which country?

- a) Malaysia b) Vietnam c) Indonesia d) Thailand

24. Which Indian fast bowler became the first to take 100 wickets each in Tests, ODIs and T20Is?

- a) Jasprit Bumrah b) Mohammed Shami c) Arshdeep Singh d) Mohammed Siraj

25. Which body approved India to host the inaugural Commonwealth Kho Kho Championship in March 2026?

- a) Commonwealth Games Federation b) Olympic Council Asia c) Kho Kho Federation d) Asian Games Council

Business & Economics

26. Indian Rupee breached which level against USD amid trade deal delays in early December 2025?

- a) ₹85 b) ₹86 c) ₹87 d) ₹88

27. Telangana Rising Global Summit 2025 secured investment commitments worth approximately?

- a) ₹3.25 lakh crore b) ₹4.50 lakh crore c) ₹5.75 lakh crore d) ₹6.10 lakh crore

28. Under Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS), Indians' annual overseas spending rose to about?

- a) USD 10 billion b) USD 17 billion c) USD 25 billion d) USD 30 billion

29. India recorded approximately how many overseas departures in 2024, driven by leisure and business travel?

- a) 2.5 crore b) 3.0 crore c) 3.89 crore d) 4.5 crore
30. Under the BS-VI norms extension announced in December 2025, which fuel standard's deadline was revised?
- a) Petrol to 2027 b) Diesel to 2028 c)
Both Petrol-Diesel to 2027 d) No extension.

ANSWER KEY

1. a	2. a	3. a	4. b	5. a	6. a	7. b	8. c	9. c	10. a
11.a	12.a	13.a	14.a	15.a	16.b	17.a	18.c	19.a	20.c
21.a	22.a	23.a	24.a	25.a	26.c	27.d	28.b	29.c	30.b

PRACTICE QUESTIONS: CIVIL SERVICES

MAINS



- Q.1** Explain the factors influencing the decision of the farmers on the selection of high value crops in India. (150 words, 10 marks)
- Q.2** Elaborate the scope and significance of supply chain management of agricultural commodities in India. (150 words, 10 marks)
- Q.3** What are the challenges before the Indian economy when the world is moving away from free trade and multilateralism to protectionism and bilateralism? How can these challenges be met? (150 words, 10 marks)
- Q.4** Discuss the rationale of the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme. What are its achievements? In what way can the functioning and outcomes of the scheme be improved? (250 words, 15 marks)
- Q.5** What causes persistent high food inflation in India? How effective is the monetary policy of the RBI in controlling this inflation? (150 words, 10 marks)

Ans. 1 High value crops are mainly horticulture crops such as fruits, flowers, spices, vegetables & aromatic plants, etc. The value of output and net returns of most of these horticulture crops is higher. Factors Influencing the decision of the Farmers on the Selection of High Value Crops in India

- **Nature of High-Value Crops:** These crops tend to offer higher net returns, which would naturally influence a farmer's decision to select them if the economic returns are attractive.
- **Economic Incentives:** High-value crops like dragon fruit and advanced banana varieties fetch higher income. ■

Government Schemes & Support: Initiatives like PM Dhan-Dhaanya Krishi Yojana and Mission for Integrated Development of Horticulture (MIDH) promote diversification, organic farming & post-harvest infra.

- **Role of FPOs and Cooperatives:** Farmer Producer Organizations (FPOs) and cooperatives strengthen bargaining power, ensure collective marketing, and reduce risks in price volatility, motivating farmers to diversify into high-value crops.

- **Expansion of Cold Chains & Logistics:** Development of cold storage, warehousing & transport facilities reduces post-harvest losses; ensures better price realization, encouraging investment in perishable high-value crops.

- **Climate Resilience & Sustainability:** Water scarcity and climate risks push farmers towards less water-intensive, resilient crops like millets and pulses.

Conclusion: With the help of such initiatives, farmers are better equipped to make informed decisions that align with both their economic goals and regional capabilities. By continuously improving these factors, India's agricultural sector is poised to further strengthen its capacity for high-value crop cultivation, thereby boosting farmers' incomes and ensuring sustainable agricultural growth.

NEW FEATURE: FOREIGN COUNTRY FOCUS

INDIA-QATAR RELATIONS: ENERGY SECURITY, DIASPORA DIPLOMACY SETS STRATEGIC EQUILIBRIUM IN WEST ASIA



“India and Qatar are not just partners in energy or trade; we are partners in people, progress, and stability.” As Qatar celebrates its Independence Day, the Ambassador of Qatar to India, ***Mohammed Hassan Jabir Al-Jabir***, in an exclusive conversation with CMDA Magazine, reflected on the enduring strength and evolving depth of our relations. Highlighting energy cooperation, the Indian diaspora, and growing strategic convergence, the Ambassador underscored how the partnership has matured into one of the most stable and mutually beneficial relationships in West Asia. “As Qatar celebrates its Independence Day, I extend my warm greetings to the people of India.” Further, he added, “our partnership is founded on energy security, human connectivity, and strategic trust..”



Introduction : Anchored in energy cooperation, sustained by a vast Indian diaspora, and increasingly shaped by converging geopolitical interests, India–Qatar ties have evolved into a multidimensional engagement that extends far beyond hydrocarbons. In an era marked by regional turbulence, great-power competition, and global energy transition, this partnership stands out for its resilience, pragmatism, and forward-looking orientation.



For India, Qatar is not merely a gas supplier; it is a critical node in India's energy security architecture, a host to one of its largest overseas communities, and an influential diplomatic actor in the Gulf. For Qatar, India represents a dependable long-term energy market, a source of skilled manpower, and a rising global power with strategic autonomy and diplomatic credibility.

Historical Background and Evolution of Ties

India-Qatar established diplomatic relations in 1973, soon after Qatar gained independence. Initially modest, the relationship gained momentum in the late 1980s and early 1990s as India liberalised its economy & Qatar emerged as a global leader in liquefied natural gas (LNG) production. The 21st century marked a qualitative shift. Energy contracts, institutional dialogues, and high-level political visits transformed the relationship from transactional to a strategic partnership, based on long-term mutual interests. Importantly, bilateral ties have remained largely insulated from ideological shifts-underscoring their pragmatic foundation.

Political and Diplomatic Engagement

- ❖ **Institutional Architecture** - India and Qatar engage through a robust institutional framework that includes: Joint Meetings, Foreign Office Consultations, Ministerial-level exchanges & Defence and security dialogues.
- ❖ High-level visits by Indian Prime Ministers, Qatari Emirs, and senior ministers have reinforced political trust and continuity.
- ❖ India's engagement with Qatar fits seamlessly within its West Asia policy, which emphasises: Strategic autonomy, Issue-based partnerships, Balanced engagement with all regional actors and Diaspora-centric diplomacy
- ❖ Qatar, for its part, values India's non-interventionist approach and its ability to maintain relations across competing power blocs.

Energy Cooperation: The Cornerstone of the Relationship



Energy cooperation, particularly LNG, forms the backbone of India–Qatar relations. Qatar is India's largest LNG supplier, accounting for a significant portion of India's long-term gas imports. India imports millions of tonnes of LNG annually, under long-term contracts-up to 25 years. These agreements provide India with price stability and supply assurance, while offering Qatar predictable

demand and revenue security. Unlike many energy relationships marked by volatility, the India–Qatar energy partnership has been characterised by reliability, even during global energy shocks such as: Oil price collapses, COVID-19 disruptions, post-Ukraine conflict energy realignments.

Strategic Implications: For India: Supports industrial growth and urban energy demand, facilitates transition from coal to cleaner fuels and enhances resilience against global spot-market fluctuations.

For Qatar: Anchors Asia as its primary energy destination, strengthens long-term market positioning amid energy transition, and reinforces its position as a reliable supplier.

- **Trade and Economic Relations Beyond Energy:** This growing economic interdependence reflects strong complementarities between capital-rich Qatar and market-rich India.
- **Bilateral Trade -** Bilateral trade between India and Qatar has consistently crossed USD 15 billion, driven primarily by energy imports but increasingly diversified.
- **India's exports to Qatar include:** Engineering and construction materials, Food products and agricultural commodities, Pharmaceuticals and medical equipment & Chemicals, plastics, and textiles.
- **Qatar's exports to India include:** LNG and LPG, Petrochemicals and Fertilisers.
- **Investment Linkages -** Qatar has emerged as a major investor in India through: Sovereign wealth funds, Infrastructure projects, Real estate ventures & Technology and start-ups.



- **Indian companies are deeply embedded in Qatar's** Construction sector, IT and digital services, Healthcare & Hospitality and logistics.

The Indian Diaspora: The Human Pillar of the Relationship: For India, the welfare of its citizens in Qatar is important. Key areas include: Labour rights protection,

Legal assistance and consular outreach, Workplace safety and Timely grievance redressal. Recent labour reforms in Qatar, including modifications to sponsorship norms, have positively impacted Indian workers and reinforced bilateral goodwill.

- **Scale and Economic Contribution** - The Indian community in Qatar numbers over 700,000, making it the largest expatriate group in the country.
- **Indian nationals are employed across:** Infrastructure and construction, Oil and gas services, Healthcare and education, Information technology and corporate management, etc.
- **They play a crucial role in Qatar's** infrastructure development, Service-sector efficiency and Knowledge transfer.

Defence and Security Cooperation – Both nations maintain cooperation in:

- ❖ Defence training, Maritime security, Naval interactions and Information exchange.
- ❖ Joint exercises and port visits have enhanced operational familiarity and strategic trust.
- ❖ Both share concerns over: Terrorism and violent extremism, Maritime security in the Gulf-Indian Ocean; Protection of energy infrastructure & sea lanes
- ❖ Qatar's diplomatic role as a mediator and India's security experience creates opportunities for coordination in regional stabilisation efforts.

Education, Culture, and Soft-Power Engagement: Indian educational institutions play an important role in Qatar's knowledge economy. Co-operation exists in:

- ❖ Engineering and medical education, Management training and Skill development programs.
- ❖ Cultural engagement has expanded through Indian cultural festivals in Doha, the promotion of yoga and Ayurveda & Film, art, and literary exchanges.
- ❖ These initiatives strengthen people-to-people ties and enhance India's soft-power footprint in the Gulf.

Multilateral and Regional Cooperation-

- India and Qatar cooperate across several multilateral platforms: United Nations, Climate change negotiations and Global energy governance forums.
- Qatar's growing diplomatic profile as mediator & humanitarian actor compliments India's emphasis on dialogue, stability & diplomacy.

Recent Developments and Emerging Trends

- Renewal and expansion of long-term LNG agreements
- Increased Qatari investment in Indian infrastructure and digital sector
- Focus on food security and supply-chain resilience
- Exploration of fintech and digital payments cooperation
- Dialogue on renewable energy and green transition

Challenges in the Relationship

Despite strong fundamentals, certain challenges persist:

- Heavy dependence on hydrocarbons in bilateral trade
- Vulnerability of migrant workers during economic downturns
- Regional geopolitical volatility
- Need for greater diversification into non-energy sectors

Conclusion: India–Qatar relations exemplify a pragmatic and resilient partnership rooted in trust, mutual benefit, and long-term vision. While energy cooperation and diaspora ties form its foundation, its broadening into new strategic, economic, and cultural domains. As global energy systems evolve and West Asia undergoes structural transformation, India and Qatar are well-positioned to elevate their engagement into a comprehensive and future-ready partnership.

THE READER'S PAGE

Editor's Note: In the reader's page this month, we present 3 selected pieces from **Nitanand Public School, Rohtak**, whose bright & motivated students have penned/ drawn some beautiful memories, which are an inspiration for all of us. We thank **Mrs Chhavi Arora, Sr Administrator & Mr Sumeet Malik, Chairman**, for this inspiration. May their students continue to excel.

The Way We Present Ourselves

The life of a senior class child (basically Classes XI and XII) is like that of a cadet undergoing training in a dream academy—full of problems and adventures, yet still holding hope to do something meaningful. Tackling yourself every day in a new, challenging way, being strong, and not losing heart are essential. Indeed, we must maintain a smile on our tense faces;



Chhavi-Class XI

hiding pain and anxiety is quite similar to having fun in the academy without fear in the eyes of one's.

Although it is difficult to control one's emotions, to overcome and achieve something, one must endure. After wearing the pride-filled uniform we once dreamed of, we now find that pain and fear become our strength and backbone. Success and satisfaction are incomplete without going through difficulties, which guide us to salute those hardships that build a bold person.

Always remember, "Hope sustains life." No matter how many ups and downs, no matter how much pain—be the best version of yourself. Pain assists development; control it and make it your strength. Always smile in difficulties and laugh in small achievements. Try to find solutions, not excuses.

The Intermediate of Eternal and Material

Being locked in a fully bright room,
unaware of the light out of the box.
Having an ability of gross to subtle zoom,
that neither become a panda nor a cunning fox.
Accidentally paced its own shadow in the square,
start observing keenly with being fully aware.
Sudden thought of realisation bloomed in the mind,
The reality darkness bright in every possible kind.
The shadow inside the box and shadow outside
is the same, and connects to the light on both sides.
In this room of bulb light, one can never think of sunlight,
the shadow is the only thing that connects to outer bright.

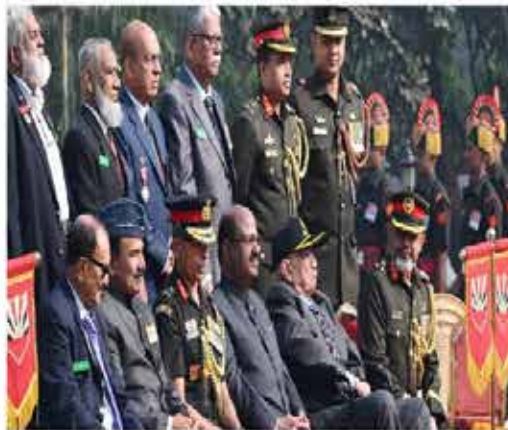


Sahil Ahlawat: Class XII



Saloni: Class IX





VIJAY DIWAS CELEBRATIONS FROM ACROSS THE COUNTRY

ABOUT US

This monthly magazine provides you all with a worldwide view of Military, Sports, National & International, Science & technology and Environmental happenings. So, let's take a dip into the realm of current affairs and events, guided by the brilliance of insights by Team CMDA. In midst of the prevailing culture of fake news and false publicity, we have attempted to convey factual and 'to the point' information for you all, under the directions and guidance of Col (Dr) Bhasker Gupta (retired). It is also being published under his sponsorship.

HIGHLIGHTS

- News on Every Subject, Duly Analysed
- Published under the Supervision of a PhD, ex Journalist & ret'd Army Officer
- 30 Questions Quiz to Rack your Brains
- Civil Services Mains Exam-Imp Ques with one answered
- Special Foreign Country Focus

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